

means you can run Windows XP within Windows 7. You will need a processor that supports virtualization though. If you have one, boot into the BIOS and turn on the feature for your processor. You should also have sufficient memory on your system for it to work well. Once you've made the change in the BIOS, boot into Windows and download the Windows XP virtual machine add on from <http://www.microsoft.com/windows/virtual-pc/download.aspx>.

This mode lets you run Windows XP applications on Windows 7 and also a copy of Windows XP within it. For most practical purposes, it's better than running a dual-boot setup.

Windows 7's resource monitor

The Windows 7 resource monitor is a powerful tool that gives detailed information on every single process and application running on the computer. Click on Start > All Programs > Accessories > System Tools > Resource monitor to access it.

There are tabs for statistics and details on CPU, memory, disk and network. The network tab is particularly useful. It gives a detail list of connections being made by every application and the bandwidth being used. If it all seems too confusing to keep track of, click on the checkbox next to the application to filter it out.

Switching back to the bare XP theme

Although Windows 7 has been optimised a lot, the default Aero theme slow down older systems. Using a basic theme like the one on Windows XP is a good idea. It helps bring down memory consumption by a lot. Some even claim that the memory consumption can be brought down to around 300 MB with no applications running. Change the mode by right-clicking on the desktop and

then on Personalize. Choose the Windows Classic Theme. To optimise things a little more, you can also turn off all the unnecessary visual effects. To do this, press the Windows key + [Pause]. Then, click on Advanced system settings. Now, click on the Setting button under Performance and click the checkbox for Adjust for best performance.

Setting up backups

Many laptop and desktop manufacturers have a separate partition in their PCs and laptops that is used to store a copy of the Windows OS. This comes in handy if your PC is infected by a virus or your OS crashes. This backup lets you quickly get your PC up and running. Windows 7 has a built-in backup utility that stores an image on a backup partition, an external hard drive or even on a network share.

To create a disk backup, click on Start > Control Panel > System and Security > Back up your computer. Click on Create a system image from the left panel. Choose where you want to save the backup and then click on Next. Just make sure that the drive has enough space to store the data. Choose the partitions you want to backup in the next step.

If you want to select folders to backup instead of an entire partition, click on Set up backup instead. Select the location where you want to back up the data, then click the radio button that lets you choose the folders you want to backup. Select the folders and finally proceed to the final steps. You can even schedule automatic backups at a fixed time.

Quick sharing of resources

Security being one of the biggest concerns, Microsoft has implemented strict security features and in the process, had made sharing folders complicated. The home group feature of Windows 7 makes sharing files in a small home

network much easier than before. The feature is only available when you set your network setup as a Home network.

Go to Control Panel > Network and Internet > Homegroup. Join a homegroup if there's one that exists already. You'll be asked to enter a password. Once you're connected to a homegroup, you'll be able to see other PCs on the homegroup in Windows Explorer. By default, Windows 7 shares the library folders for music, videos, etc. For home groups to work, PCs need to be running Windows 7 with IPv6 support enabled in their network settings.

digiKam

digiKam is an application to manage your images and photos and also allows users to edit and batch process images to change format or add extra effects. It's available for Windows as well as Linux. However, here we are going to discuss the Linux version.

Setting up digiKam

First you need to setup the digiKam default folder. To do so, go to Settings and select Configure digiKam. Under Album settings, you can add the folder path where you want digiKam to search for folders and premade

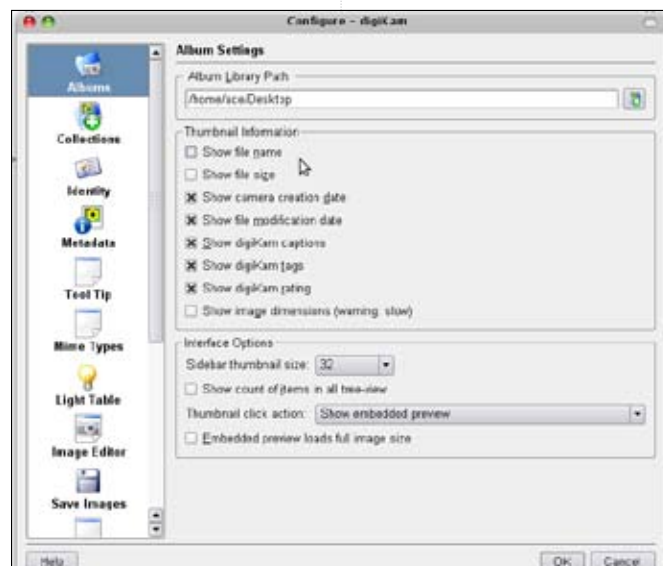
albums. You can also configure thumbnails in this window. You can sort your albums according to collections; preset collections are available, but you can modify them under Collections in the configure window.

Customise shortcuts

You might not use all the shortcuts in digiKam, but at the same time, might want to use certain key combinations that are in use by other functions so to change these shortcuts go to Settings and select Configure Shortcuts. You can even add numbers or alphabets as shortcuts to certain functions.

Viewing Images according to date

The digiKam application allows you to view images according to when they were created. Even if there are images in an album which have been downloaded, you can separate them according to the date they were created and uploaded to the net. There is a small tool bar located on the extreme left of the screen. By default, the Albums tab is selected. Below that is the Calendar tab. Here you will see a My Calendar window with the year displayed. On expanding one of the years, you will see months. Click on any month to see the images created in that month. A small calendar



Set the default album folder for digiKam